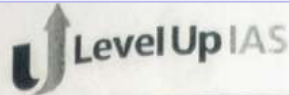


Q.2a (20 marks): Mead's major contribution to anthropological theory - importance of cultural conditioning



- Q4. (a) Mead's major contribution to anthropological theory was her demonstration of the importance of cultural rather than biological conditioning. Elaborate with relevant examples and case studies. (20 marks)

Margaret Mead belongs to the culture personality school of thought which tends to understand the relation between culture & personality in an anthropo-psychological approach.

She postulates against the then popular concept of biological determinism and instead ~~post~~ proposed that Culture affects Personality (i.e. cultural determinism).

MAJOR WORKS

1) "Coming of Age in Samoa" : She shows how adolescents in Samoa are more peaceful & ^{less} rebellious ~~than~~ & engage in sexual relations more freely as compared to American adolescents who rather have a conflicting moral based, more rebellious adolescence. This she says is due to enculturation practices in Samoa which discuss matters of age, sex etc at early age.

2) "Lex and Temperament in Three Primitive societies"

She shows how in three societies living in close proximity to each other there is a difference in gender roles owing to culture ^{differs}

Arapesh

live in isolated place free from enemy attack
↓
men & women both submissive

Mondagumas

constant threat & hence competition fear etc.
↓
Men & women both aggressive

Tschambuli

more interested of female in economy
↓
highly skilled men aggressive women

Thus she says personalities of men & women are shaped by their cultures.

3) "And Keep Your Powder Dry": National Character Study among Japanese, the Russians & Americans whose children were the same personalities when infants but later as enculturation affects there is difference in personalities which occurs.
The nature acting over nature (genes) (culture)

4) She also writes on how cultural restrictions have shaped personalities of women to be subordinate and hence actively worked in feminist movements.

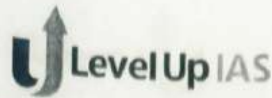
Relativism Methodology :

- 1) Visual & photographic methods
- 2) Content analysis method
- 3) EMIC view of study

Criticism :

- 1) Mauri Harris : criticises here 'emic' mode of study (lack of holism) & also sampling errors : Mead's sample study has only adolescent girls & no one to validate
- 2) Derek Freeman accuses here of fabricating the data in order to prove a pre-conceived theory

Q.2b (15 marks): Cultural practices and beliefs as adaptive responses to environmental and economic constraints



(Don't Write anything in this Area)

3) Crisis of representation critique: samples too small to represent whole population.

4) Over generalistic and unscientific

Relevance :

1) Can help establish against the social determinations

2) Culture conditioning & reconditioning practices are now given even more importance with specialised institutions emerging for it.

3) These thoughts became the basis of feminist school of anthropology.

Thus Margaret Mead has been one of the most influential anthropologist whose works raised scholarly debate & also attracted popular support with equal vigor.